

What a defensible forensic report contains

A section-by-section checklist for the written part of an investigation, usable as a template for students and as a grading guide for instructors. The order is the order a reader needs it: conclusion first, proof after, detail last.

1. Front matter

- ☐ Case identifier, report date, report version
- ☐ Examiner name, role and contact; organization
- ☐ Requesting party and the question they asked, in their words
- ☐ Classification or handling marking if any

2. Executive summary (half a page)

- ☐ What was examined, in one sentence
- ☐ Each conclusion as a plain statement with a confidence level
- ☐ What could not be determined and why
- ☐ No tool names, no hashes, no jargon the requester would not use

3. Scope and authority

- ☐ Items received, each with number, description and hash
- ☐ Who collected them, when, and the chain of custody reference
- ☐ Questions in scope; questions explicitly out of scope
- ☐ Authority to examine (consent, warrant, policy, course assignment)

4. Methodology

- ☐ Tools with versions; verification that the image hash matched before analysis
- ☐ Write-blocking or working-copy procedure
- ☐ Time zone used throughout, and how it was established
- ☐ Any deviation from standard procedure, with the reason

5. Findings

- ☐ One finding per heading, each answering one question from the scope
- ☐ Every factual claim tied to a specific artifact: path, record, offset or event, and a timestamp
- ☐ Screenshots or extracts only where they prove something; captioned
- ☐ Observation and interpretation kept in separate sentences
- ☐ Alternative explanations considered and, where possible, ruled out

6. Timeline

- ☐ Chronological table: time (one zone), source artifact, event, significance
- ☐ Only events that support a finding; the full export goes in an appendix
- ☐ Gaps and clock problems called out, not smoothed over

7. Conclusions

- ☐ Restate each question and answer it directly
- ☐ Confidence stated and justified by the findings section
- ☐ Limitations: missing evidence, anti-forensics, time
- ☐ Recommendations only if asked for them

8. Appendices

- ☐ Evidence manifest with hashes; chain of custody forms
- ☐ Full tool output referenced in the findings
- ☐ Glossary for the non-technical reader
- ☐ Examiner qualifications

Common ways student reports lose marks. Conclusions that are not in the findings. A finding with no artifact behind it. Mixed time zones. "The malware" when the evidence shows "an executable named". A summary written last and longest instead of first and shortest. Screenshots of a whole screen when one line was the point.